

Patrick Forsyth



B2B Selling Skills

Outsmarting Your Competitors

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B2B Selling Skills: Outsmarting Your Competitors

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THE AUTHOR

Patrick Forsyth is a consultant, trainer and writer. He has worked with organisations large and small and in many different parts of the world. He is the author of many successful books on management, business and careers and prides himself on having a clear how-to style.

One reviewer (“Professional Marketing”) commented: *Patrick has a lucid and elegant style of writing which allows him to present information in a way that is organised, focused and easy to apply.*

In this series he is also the author of several titles including “Your boss: sorted!” and “How to get a pay rise”. His writing extends beyond business. He has had published humorous books (e.g. *Empty when half full*) and light-hearted travel writing: *First class at last!*, about a journey through South East Asia, and *Smile because it happened* about Thailand. His novel, *Long Overdue*, was published recently.

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1 INTRODUCTION: A KEY PERSONAL SKILL

God is on the side not of the heavy battalions, but of the best shots.

– Voltaire

The selling process in context

Selling – the personal interaction between buyer and seller – is a key part of the overall marketing process. In many B2B businesses it is the final link. In other words whatever other marketing activity has been undertaken, from sending a brochure or mailing to running a major advertising campaign, and however much interest it has generated, selling must convert that interest – building on what has been done in publicity and service and turning it into action to buy.

Sometimes the sales process consists of a single event – you talk to the customer and, all being well, they buy. On other occasions the nature of B2B products and the customers' attitude to it mean that a whole series of events must take place. These range from a simple enquiry to a series of meetings and maybe more besides (sending a written proposal or making a presentation, for instance). All of this is important and whatever is done it must be done well; however the focus here is primarily on the face-to-face interaction between sales people and customers.

The sales task is to communicate clearly and persuasively, and very often to *differentiate* an offering from that of competition. It is a fragile process, meaning that results can be changed – for good or ill – by small changes in approach. This may even go down to the use of one word rather than another, certainly to one description or another. Markets may be competitive, customers demanding and fickle, and selling success will not “just happen” because you have a good product or the “gift of the gab”. You must outsmart competition to outsell them. But of one thing you can be sure:

Selling success can be made more certain if you understand the way the process works and deploy the right techniques in the right way.

Think about any skill. Can you juggle with three flaming torches without burning holes in the carpet? Maybe not, but there are people who can. What is the difference between them and you? Perhaps only that they have thought about how to do it, understand how to go about it and have practised doing it. Selling is no different.

The archetypal “born salesman” is rare indeed. Good sales people, however, are much more common. And the best of them have a secret. They understand the process of buying and selling. They adopt a conscious approach in the light of that understanding, and they deploy an approach that utilises well-chosen techniques that are in turn well matched to each individual customer or prospect with which they are dealing.

The overall prevailing standard of salesmanship is by no means all good, and there is much that is bad or at least unthinking and poorly focused on customers. Many sales people muddle through thinking that all that is necessary is a personable approach – *if people like me they will buy from me* – they say. They make sales (provided the product is good) but they will never sell as much as they could.

What does all this mean? *It means that those who tackle this area and get it right have a considerable opportunity to maximise sales results and thus positively influence the growth and profitability of the business.*

Selling is the most personal area of marketing. It is what *you* do that can guarantee success, *what* you say and *how* you say it. The intention here is to provide guidelines and approaches that will enable you to sharpen your sales skills and maximise the results they produce. Nothing here is intellectually taxing. Selling – good selling – is to a large extent common sense. It does, however, involve some complexity. In a sales meeting that lasts even half an hour (and some last much longer) there is a great deal happening and many things to remember and get right.

Furthermore, the same solution and approach is not right for every customer, much less for every occasion. Rather an appropriate way forward must be found literally day-by-day, customer-by-customer and meeting-by-meeting. Selling is dynamic and changing market situations demand a flexible approach. The best sales people do not operate by rote, they do not “script” their presentation and they are always conscious of the fine detail of what they do. Indeed, a specific and individual customer focus is essential to everything in selling and is a theme here.

The text shows you how:

- To view the process of buying and selling
- To understand and utilise the psychology of human nature that is involved in making buying decisions – turning theory into practice if you like
- To adopt tried and tested approaches that give you the best chance of differentiating yourself and your product in a crowded market and successfully persuading your customers to buy, to buy again and to buy more.

No fancy gimmicks are necessary; the most important element here is *you*. You can make your selling truly effective just by the way you go about it.

This text addresses a key personal skill, that of being persuasive in face to face sales meetings. Further, it is not just a skill you must develop, but one that must be deployed productively, because unless you achieve a good success rate (converting a good proportion of the leads and situations that you pursue) it will affect your profitability.

2 SELLING IN CONTEXT

Before getting into the detail of how to go about the process, four overriding factors are important to note.

- *Persuasive communication – selling (professional selling) – has a complex job to do: it must inform, persuade and differentiate.* While nothing about selling is itself intellectually taxing, and much of what makes it work is common sense, it needs careful orchestrating and any complexity is created by the fact that many aspects of the process need deploying accurately and in parallel
- *Selling is inherently fragile.* By this I mean that it is sensitive to small change: something done a little differently can make the difference between agreement and rejection. Details matter: even a poor choice of a few key words of description can affect the outcome.
- *Selling must be acceptable to the client.* There is a fear among some that too strong (“pushy”) an approach is incompatible with projecting a professional image, and indeed it could be so. Well considered sales approaches, however, can help create, retain, and even enhance, the professional relationship that you are at pains to work within
- *Selling must be deployed in a tailored manner.* There are certainly principles to be borne in mind, but there is no one right way to sell. We can all spend a lifetime learning to adapt better and better to changing conditions and, not least, client demands and expectations. What is necessary is to sell in the best way – whatever that is – every time, meeting by meeting, client by client approaches must be well matched to the circumstances.

No matter how well executed and how creative promotional processes are deployed, they will still, if successful, not produce any new clients of themselves. What they will produce, if successful, is prospects – those sufficiently interested to say ‘*Tell me more*’. The only thing that can convert that interest into agreement that will produce fees is personal persuasive skills.

It is this final, and personal, part of the marketing process that this text reviews. Success is to an extent in the details, so the process will be dissected and how each element helps the whole examined. It may appear to start with the basics. Indeed it does; but bear in mind the word ‘fragile’ used earlier, you need to understand the detail to deploy the techniques appropriately and to make them successful. And to do so every time.

Certain points which appear in this section are designed to illustrate key points at which what is being done can be made more persuasive, more likely to *differentiate* you from competition. Also, to show how greater persuasiveness can be positioned so that it adds improved client awareness and service, from the prospect's point of view.

We will start by reviewing the nature of the sales process, then turn to the face-to-face situation and then to follow-up activity and other communication techniques.

Fundamentals of success

Whatever you sell, and often in B2B selling products and services are regarded as high cost, clients want to be sure they are dealing with the right firm and the right people. And they will define doing so as working with the one with whom there is the greatest certainty of achieving what they want.

Put yourself in the clients' shoes for a moment. How do they know a product will work for them? In many ways the answer, if they have not used you or your organisation before (and to a degree if they have), is simple. They judge you in part from the way you do what you do first: sell.

Of course, you and your colleagues are good with people, you are professionally competent and, what is more, you are nice people to do business with. Surely if you create the right relationship their business will follow? Well, perhaps. However, is it just possible that the other organisations being checked out have some pleasant and efficient people too? They want you to be knowledgeable, efficient, and reliable; they may want you to have expert knowledge of particular things; they certainly want to feel you understand them, their business and their situation and to act with that understanding in mind as you match them with appropriate products.

Now you and any other people in your firm may be exceptional, able to do the best job possible for a wide range of clients, but, as has been said, the client has to be persuaded of this fact. It follows, as night follows day, that the first chance (and perhaps the only chance) you will have of demonstrating your professional competence is when you are selling. Your excellence may shine through instantly when your products are actually delivered but unless you are well-judged your product may never be bought.

This fact, and the fragile nature of the sales process, both referred to earlier, makes it paramount that every element of persuasive communication – professional selling – is done correctly, with 'done correctly' meaning done in a way that will maximise the chances of people doing business with you.

A further point is worth adding to this explanation of why selling is so important. And that is productivity. Sales productivity, that is. The opportunity cost of everything you do, other than doing is considerable. If things are being done inadequately, two meetings where one should have sufficed, or if the success rate of new clients in relationship to the number of prospects with whom you are in discussion is too low, then it becomes a disproportionately expensive process. The time taken for selling must be kept as low as possible to maximise profitability.

Selling is:

- A *sequential* and *staged* process. Occasionally one meeting may lead directly to business; more often a number of different interactions are necessary, building up the case and finally converting the interest generated into commitment.
- A *cumulative* process. In other words, each stage has to go right, the prospect can lose interest or drop out at any stage and at every stage they may well be making comparisons with how a competing firm goes through the process. Literally, if one stage is judged inadequate by the prospect, there may well be no chance to move on to the next stage at all.
- The stages clearly involve different *methods of communication*, all of which must be handled with equal effectiveness. What is done must be equally persuasive, no matter whether it involves a simple one-to-one meeting, a telephone call, written communication (letters or longer, more complex proposals and so on), or a formal “stand-up” presentation. Each method presents its own challenges, may demand somewhat different skills and none must be a weak link in the chain of communication resulting in definite business.

To a degree this means that selling is a complex process. Remember none of the things that must be done are intellectually taxing, indeed much sale technique is based on common sense, but it must be carefully orchestrated to create the best approach. Habits and reflexes must be built up and some aspects can only be refined through experience. It is certain that many people can be effective in selling, provided the task is approached thoroughly, systematically and creatively.

The basis for the techniques involved is similar, regardless of method and must reflect not only the sales objectives but also the way clients buy B2B products. In addition, everything we will now deal with can be used in contacts with:

- Existing clients (those already worked for and their colleagues in the same company);
- Enquirers (those who take the initiative and make the first contact requesting information, advice or discussion); and, as appropriate, with
- Intermediaries (those who can recommend you to others).

The word ‘prospect’ is used to indicate people who might have a need for your products or services, but are not yet clients. It is to the client’s thinking that we now turn.

The basis for sales technique

The core of what makes the basis for sales technique, is twofold and both elements start on the client’s side of the relationship. First, we must consider the way in which people *buy*. Much as anybody does when buying anything else, those buying B2B products investigate options and weigh up the pros and cons of any given case (and often, of course, they are intentionally checking out several options alongside each other).

How do they do this? They go through a particular sequence of thinking, one identified by psychologists way back and paraphrased here. They say to themselves:

- I am important and want to be respected
- Consider my needs
- Will your ideas help me?
- What are the facts?
- What are the snags?
- What shall I do?
- I approve/disapprove.

Each step in the process must be taken before the buyer will willingly move on to the next one. Some decisions can be taken at once while others require a pause between each stage.

In buying decisions follow this seven-stage process, but execution of the process can be much more complex due to the nature of the client’s business; the size of the organisation; the people and functions involved; their needs, and the degree of influence they had on buying decisions. Selling is best viewed from this perspective. It is not something that you do *to* people, it is the mirror image of the buying process – something that is inherently two way.

Selling: is best viewed as helping people to buy.

Selling is a process of need satisfaction and research shows two facts that are extremely valuable to sellers. First, that interviews are much more successful when the client's needs are clearly identified. Secondly, as a result they are less successful when their needs are only implied. Asking is thus as important as telling.

Nothing is successfully sold unless a client willingly buys. This encouraged by offering satisfied needs as reasons for buying, i.e. perfect holes, not precision drills; reduced administrative costs, not computer programs. To follow the buying mind's seven-step process is vital in effective selling. There is a need to relate what is done in selling closely to the client's point of view; this can only be done if it is thought through carefully. Your sales approach must be, in a word: planned.

Planning for success

If you appear, indeed, are more attuned to the client's thinking than others, you will create a better, and easier, basis for everything you do. So, *the first rule about preparing to sell is simple – you must do it*. Perhaps more business is lost because people believe that what needs to be done can be done 'off the top of the head' than for any other reason. Conversely, it seems apparent that successful salespeople, in any field in fact, are always those that do their homework.

Preparation may mean a moment's thought before you enter someone's office; a few minutes with the file, notes etc.; or a couple of hours (or more) sitting round the table with colleagues to thrash out the best approach to a major sales prospect.

Such preparation allows you to ensure that:

- The meeting focuses on the individual prospect;
- You are more fluent and confident in what you want to do and can save time (a valuable resource for both parties).

The process of planning is similar whether you plan to see an existing client, a new prospect or if a really major project is in view. It is an opportunity to:

- Do any necessary research (looking into the nature of the prospect organisation and the person/people you will meet)
- Set clear objectives (what – exactly – you intend to achieve at the end of the meeting)
- Work out the shape of the meeting you want to run (not to prohibit flexibility, but to give you a main option and promote it)
- Identify the areas of questioning you will need to pursue (to identify needs; see later)
- Organise any support elements (what do you need to have with you and/or show/discuss with them)
- Consider fall back positions and different options (you cannot, even with good planning expect everything to always go exactly as you wish).

You will always be able to perform better if you have thought things through; what is more your planning shows and people like it if you have taken trouble to relate to them properly.



Client strategy

Finally, in planning, there is the need to take a longer-term view, a ‘client strategy’ for those major clients, which in most firms produces a significant proportion of total fees and, hopefully, profit. Such clients, because of their complexity and power, are different in nature as well as size. They are not like all other clients, only bigger. This can rapidly be demonstrated by considering the effect of losing one. It is, therefore, vital that the relationship with them proceeds purposefully over a long period and this normally means planning at least a year ahead. Thus, the elements to be considered in developing a major client strategy of this sort include:

- Contacts in the client organisation
- Other contacts (colleagues/associates)
- Assignment analysis last year, including any trends or opportunities identified
- Competitive activity, and relative strengths and weaknesses in terms of service, fees and terms, and ‘presentation’
- Next year’s objectives
- Overall strategy statement
- Detailed action plans
- Contacts to be made
- Objectives of calls – support required – timing and deadlines.

Planning tends to be a weak area. Strengths can be maximised in face-to-face situations by thorough planning, so that the possibility of client rejection caused by unforeseen errors is reduced to a minimum. It is also clearly better to be aiming to create, at least to some extent, the client and work mix you want, rather than simply juggling to accommodate whatever comes up.

As a final plea not to forget or underestimate the necessity for planning and preparation consider the following. It is any buyer’s job to get the best possible deal for his company. That is what they are paid for, they are not actually on the salesmen’s side, and will attempt to get the better of them in every way, especially on discounts.

This is well illustrated by the apocryphal story of the fairground strongman. During his act he took an orange, put it in the crook of his arm and bending his arm squeezed the juice out. He then challenged the audience offering £10 to anyone able to squeeze out another drop. After many had tried unsuccessfully, one apparently unlikely candidate came forward, he squeezed and squeezed and finally out came a couple more drops. The strongman was amazed, and, seeking to explain how this was possible, asked as he paid out the £10 what the man did for a living. 'I am a buyer with the Ford Motor Company', he replied.

Buyers are not really like this; they are worse.

If you sold to the motor trade you would recognise this instantly, but a serious point is made; when people wear their buying hat they are not on your side. They are concerned with *their* situation and needs, and they are getting more and more professional at going through a process which gets them, as they see it, what they want.

Preparation in all its forms is often skimmed so, while pressure of work (not least client pressure) may make it difficult, you will find it is a very worthwhile investment and an important, easy step towards positive differentiation to make sure you do it.

All the factors mentioned to date have a direct link to what should be done in face to face sales meetings: this is the main message so let's turn to that now.

3 FACE TO FACE: THE SHAPE OF A SALES MEETING

So, having thought about the sales process, and what we are going to do regarding a particular meeting, the next step is to run the meeting. And, run the meeting is right. It is important to see it as something to direct, with yourself in the driving seat. Specifically:

Resolve to get hold of the meeting: you *should run the kind of meeting you want, and clients find that they like* – and preferably like better than they do any competitors’, you will then give yourself a head start.

The simple procedure of, for example, suggesting an agenda can help you get hold of the meeting. An agenda that suits you, but that also makes sense to the client, and is certainly phrased that way, *‘It might be most helpful to you, Mr Client, if we were to take...first, then...’*. This is an excellent example of what was mentioned earlier, sales technique coming over to the client as helpful and focusing on their needs. They are at liberty to amend your list, but you are likely to end up following broadly your suggestion.

Thereafter, the meeting will fall essentially into four parts:

- An opening, predominantly concerned with the identification and analysis of client needs
- A ‘presentation’ of your response to those needs, offering solutions
- Dealing with resistance (a less clear stage, since objections can come at any time)
- Obtaining willing commitment to proceed further.

What that final ‘willing commitment’ is to, or at least what it might be to, must be borne in mind from the start of the meeting. In some meetings the aim is to agree a sale; in others it is to agree to a next, firm, stage along the way – another meeting, the preparation of a proposal or whatever. In others it is just to obtain more information or an introduction to a decision-maker. Clearly, the more tangible a step forward is achieved the better, and having the ideal in mind throughout the meeting, makes it more likely to occur, as you wish.

Now, we will consider the four stages in turn.

i) Identifying and analysing client needs

Client attitudes vary at the beginning of interviews. They can be friendly, hostile, indifferent, interested, helpful or defensive. You may detect very particular attitudes. For example someone may be wary, conscious of dealing with an area in which they are not expert; this is most true with technical products of which computer related kit is a good example. Or they may be worried and see a risk ahead, something must be sorted out or they will be blamed – and to do it they have to put themselves in someone else's hands. The opening of an interview is therefore a crucial time for both parties.

Remember the first two steps in the buying process.

I am important and want to be respected – consider my needs.

These two steps make the seller's objectives at the beginning of all interviews very clear:

- To make the client feel important in their eyes
- To agree the client's stated needs.

Successful selling is particularly dependent on this stage in the buying process being well handled. Exploring, identifying and agreeing to the client's needs correctly makes them want to hear the proposition. Subsequently, making it attractive reduces the possibility of objections and thus obtains more voluntary commitment.

Often people will volunteer their needs and priorities – sometimes even doing so accurately! But surprisingly often they may have only a vague idea what is wrong (assuming a problem) or of what they want. This may be for all sorts of reasons: say inexperience or not having thought it through. Sometimes too they may think they know what is needed but be basing their view on a misconception of some sort. Often, therefore, needs have to be explored, identified and spelt out before they can be agreed and priorities set.

It is not putting it too strongly to suggest that this is a 'sheep and goats' factor in selling. That is, those who find out more about client needs, really find out, and are seen to do so by the client, have a head start on everything else that follows. *It can be the first step to beating competition.*

So how do you go about it? Exploration can be carried out either by questions or statements, or by a combination of both questions and statements. Questions are initially safer and more productive, but they have to be carefully and correctly used.

The questioning technique most likely to bring results utilises four basic types of question:

- Background questions – for example, *‘What’s your unit cost per item?’*
- Problem questions – for example, *‘Are unit costs a problem?’*
- Implication questions – for example, *‘What effect are high unit costs having on the rest of the business?’*
- Need questions – for example, *‘What would you like to happen as far as unit costs are concerned?’*

Such questions are best used in sequence. Open or closed questions can be equally successful, but open questions (that cannot be answered with ‘yes’ or ‘no’) encourage others to talk and produce more information. The type and combination of questions used is very important. Experience shows that asking fewer background questions but focusing them better, asking more problem questions, amplifying problems by asking implication questions and converting problems and implications into need questions works best and forms a logical sequence. By contrast asking a relatively large number of background questions, fewer problem, implication or need questions, and introducing solutions after the stage of asking background questions works less well.

The reason for this difference in the success rate is very simple. The first follows the client’s buying sequence, the latter makes you talk about yourself, your organisation and your products and services which distances you from the client.

Each type of question has an equivalent approach based on a statement, where the same sequence can be used as with questions, namely Background – Problems -Implications – Needs, and statements can be most confidently used when the seller already has a thorough understanding of the client’s situation. Thus, they are more often used after questioning or during subsequent meetings.

Clients with strongly felt needs will often buy with very little encouragement. Many clients, however, are satisfied with existing solutions. They will maintain the status quo unless something causes them to become dissatisfied. Sellers faced with this situation must, in fact, create some dissatisfaction before the client will consider a change. This must be done without criticising the client’s previous decisions, which may well create a defensive feeling. This can most readily be done by showing that due to factors outside their control, the situation is unsatisfactory. Many outside factors can be used in this way: other people’s actions and attitudes; the behaviour of materials, products or systems; market forces and local, national or world-wide events; natural phenomena like the weather and many others.

Clients will normally have a mix of needs and they will rarely be equally important. The next stage, as a client's needs are established, is to identify and agree their relative *priority*. Questions that will establish this must, therefore, be included in the early stages of conversation. This is important as clients have a habit of saying that something *must be...* and then listing things. Often there is a clash. They want something at the most economic price (don't we all?) and also want a rapid conclusion and result. Which is most important? Maybe getting things done earlier will also cost more – such things need sorting out.

This early stage is vital, since, as the old saying has it, 'You get only one chance to make a good first impression'. Not only are clients making judgements on competence and approach at this stage, but the success of all that follows is dependent on the information base being established. What precisely is done next will be based on this information, and is the first step towards an approach that will differentiate you from your competitors and secure the business in competitive situations.

ii) Offering solutions: making a persuasive case

Once needs are identified and priorities established, the next step is to show how satisfaction will come from the specific services or recommendations that you offer. Again the action springs from the appropriate stage of the buying process. The client's mental demands are as follows.

Will your ideas help me? What are the snags?

This means that the seller has four objectives: to make their ideas understandable, attractive and convincing, and to get feedback that the first three have been successfully achieved.

Each of these elements must be considered in turn and they then have to be deployed together in a cohesive and effective conversation.

Making ideas understandable

Three main factors affect this:

- *Structure and sequence:* What you present at a meeting should always be structured around the client's needs, thus *'so in choosing a system, your first concern is compatibility, your second is simplicity, and your third is productivity. Let's look at the compatibility aspect first, and then deal with the others...'*

It is also important to conclude one aspect before moving to the next, to take matters in a logical order and, if necessary to spell out what the logic is, saying perhaps: *Let's look at the project chronologically.*

- *Visual aids:* People understand and remember more when information is presented in visual form. Charts, diagrams, slides, pictures and brochures can all strengthen the clarity of the presentation. In using them follow the basic rules, keep them hidden until they are needed, keep quiet while they are being examined (people cannot concentrate on two things at once) and remove them after use to avoid any distraction. Clients like it too if some of the material has clearly been produced uniquely for your meeting with *them*, if so, some things can incorporate the client's name or logo somewhere. The product itself is similarly important: see "demonstrating" later.
- *Jargon:* Every company and industry has its own language or jargon and your field of expertise is probably no exception. Some jargon can be useful, if pitched at the right level, implying mutual understanding. But overall the presentation must use the client's language. This means using words and terms that you are certain the client understands and avoiding words or terms which can be misinterpreted in any way, even simple ones – '*our product is cheap*'.

In a technical business, the aspect of making things understood, clearly understood, can be easily overlooked (you may feel you need some help in making things more persuasive, but surely not simply in explaining your activity, services or a particular approach). Make sure you really do explain clearly. At least as many prospects are lost solely because they are confused as because they are inadequately convinced. Check if you are not sure. And remember that unexpected clarity when discussing something a client expects to be complicated will always please – it speaks volumes for your professionalism.

Making ideas attractive

This is the heartland of what makes your case persuasive. People buy things for what they will do (i.e. benefits: that is desirable results from the listener's point of view) not for what they are (features). Products can do many different things for clients, but not all clients want the same things done. Thus, only those benefits which meet identified needs should be mentioned and it is the process of selecting and matching items from the total list of benefits to an individual prospect's specific requirements that makes a particular idea, or solution, appear attractive. Note that *benefits are not what you sell or do – a product or whatever – rather they are what this does for the client. Talk about results and you will always be more persuasive.*

There are normally three types of benefit which can be used:

- Benefits to the individual in their job
- Benefits to the person themselves
- Benefits to others in whom they are interested

The choice will depend on the needs and priorities; most often a mix works best.

This benefit-oriented basis of description in talking with clients is vital. It is another ‘sheep and goats’ factor. The most successful sellers do not sell simply their products or services – they sell benefits; that is what clients want to buy. But what, exactly, are benefits? This is worth a moment’s careful consideration.

Benefits are what products or services *do* for the client. It is not important what they are, but what they do or mean for the client. To take an everyday example, a person does not buy an electrical drill because they want an electric drill, but because they want to be able to make holes. They buy holes, not a drill. They buy the drill for what it will do (make holes) and this in turn may only be important to them because they want to put up shelving as they need more storage space. As the cosmetics manufacturer famously said: *I don’t sell cosmetics; I sell hope.*

B2B selling is normally concerned with results – the situation once something is purchased and in use. Even the simplest kind of thing works in this way – a client does not want a new brochure designed, they want to sell more (as a result of having an improved brochure).

Realising this not only makes selling more effective, but also makes it more straightforward to do well. You do not have to try to sell the same standard thing to a lot of different people, but meet each person’s needs with personal benefits. Benefits are what the things you sell can do for each individual client – the things they want them to do for them. Different clients buy the same thing for different reasons. It is important, therefore, to identify and use the particular benefits of interest to each. What a product ‘is’ is represented by its ‘features’. What a product ‘does’ is described by its benefits.

The client is most unlikely to see things from the seller's point of view. Everyone sees themselves as the most important person in the world. Therefore, to be successful, any seller must be able to see things from the client's point of view, and demonstrate through their words and actions that they have done so. The chances of success are greater if you can understand the needs of the people you talk to and make them realise that you can fulfil those needs – and deliver the results they want. The word here is *empathy: the ability to put yourself in other peoples' shoes and see things from their point of view, and importantly (in selling) to be seen to be doing so.*

This is essentially achieved by the correct use of benefits. In presenting any proposition to a client, even simply recommending something in reply to a query, you should always translate what you are offering into what it will do. It is especially easy in technical areas to focus on features, adding more and more features as services are refined and improved. It is only a small step before everyone is busy trying to sell services on their features alone.

When competitive firms' products or services are almost identical in their performance – at least from a prospect's viewpoint, it can be difficult to sell benefits, since they all seem to offer the same benefits. Choice, then, often depends on the personal appeal of some secondary factor. But even then, there must be emphasis on the benefits derived from those features, rather than on the features themselves. Features are only important if they support the benefits that the customer is interested in.

Deciding to concentrate on describing benefits is only half the battle, however. They have to be the right benefits. In fact, benefits are only important to a client if they describe the satisfaction of his needs. Working out the needs, and then the benefits, means being 'in the client's shoes'. To know which benefits to put forward, you must understand the need. Organisations may often have more than one decision-maker, therefore, it is essential to pinpoint your contact within the hierarchy in order to relate to them accurately. Sometimes different points need making to different people.

To do this it is useful to analyse services in terms of features and benefits. Thus an accountant, say, might contrast:

- *Benefit:* provides a quicker, more certain audit analysis with less disruption of the accounts department, and results available for action sooner
- *Feature:* a computer-assisted audit.

How can you be sure you're talking about benefits? Analysing your offering in advance will help. So too will two checks. Play it over in your mind. If what you say seems likely to prompt the response "So what?" you are probably talking about a feature. If you follow what you are talking about by the words "Which means that..." and there is no more to say then you are talking benefits. If there is more to say then you are talking about a feature and completing the thought "Which means that..." will give voice to the benefit.

An analysis can be produced for every item you sell, and can be presented within a seller's organisation to help everyone learn which points are features and which are benefits. Note that not all the needs will be objective ones; most buyers also have subjective requirements bound up in their decisions. Even with technical services the final decisions can sometimes be heavily influenced by subjective factors, perhaps seemingly of minor significance, once people are content that all the objective needs have been met.

By matching benefits to individual client needs, you are more likely to make a sale, for the benefits of any product must match a buyer's needs. The features only give rise to the right benefits. By going through this process for particular products and for segments of your range, and matching the factors identified to client needs, a complete 'databank' of information from the client viewpoint can be assembled.

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With the competition becoming increasingly similar, more buyers quickly conclude that their main needs can be met equally well by more than one firm. Other needs then become more important. If, for instance, a buyer needs, say, I.T. advice, he is likely to find a number of firms which all offer the service required, and all of which will cost practically the same.

The deciding factors may then become people, availability, service, specialist knowledge and so on. The seller must therefore look at the 'features' contained by the firm as a whole and be ready to convert them into benefits to clients – in the same way as we can practise finding benefits for the full service range.

What is it about your offering that gives rise to benefits?

All aspects of the 'features', whether to do with the products and services themselves, or the manner in which they are provided by the firm or its staff, are sources of benefit to clients. Such factors include:

- Price/fee levels
- Availability of service or staff
- Credit
- Expertise
- Specialist knowledge
- Speed of action
- Training assistance
- Quality/objectivity of advice
- Time firms have been established
- Reputation, location, philosophy, size policies, financial and international standing
- The character, style and manner of you, and of any staff or associates.

Each item listed above, and more, could be a source of benefit to potential clients and help convert them into actual clients. By 'thinking benefits' and by seeing things from the clients' point of view, you can increase the contribution made to producing new business and increasing your firm's profitability.

Knowing how and why clients view you as they do, is a prerequisite to improving all the specific communication areas reviewed here and to making your own use of them become more effective.

Talking benefits is always a basic component of an effective sales approach; it translates the case into clients' terms, and makes it absolutely clear you are seeing things from the client's point of view. Check you are doing it justice; all the briefing and much of the thinking about the firm, and its services will be introspective, and may prompt an introspective view and approach, unless you do so.

Making ideas convincing

If benefits are claims for what you offer, such claims may have to be substantiated, as sales claims – about anything – are always viewed with some scepticism. This can be done by describing the features that produce them, or by reference to third parties.

Third party references must be used only to support your case, and not as arguments in themselves. If a specific third party is named, it should be one respected by the listener, and should face similar conditions to those of the client. A third party should not just be mentioned, but also linked to a description of the particular benefits and need satisfactions that they obtained.

Thus, consider the statements:

- *'I conduct practical workshops to develop presentation skills in senior staff.'*
- *'I conduct...and have run such events for X and Y' [where X and Y are appropriately chosen firms].*
- *'I conduct...for X and Y. In the case of Y, we were able to incorporate rehearsals of actual planned client presentations, which they were convinced then went better as a result.'*

Each is progressively more powerful. If a specific example of business gained can be added to the third, so much the better.

How else can you phrase things?

You need to create a fluent conversation rather than use these techniques mechanistically. Varying the way you use benefits and adding power – and credibility – in different ways helps the process. The following illustrate this, you can use:

- *A simple statement B – F* For example, 'You will get more sales if you use Benefits that match the client's needs.'
- *A comparison statement B – F – WA – NE:* For example, 'You will get more sales if you use Benefits that match the client's Needs. Vague or unrelated Benefits have a low impact.'

- *Sandwich statements B – F – WA – NE – F – B*: For example, ‘You will get more sales if you use Benefits that match the client’s Needs. Vague or unrelated Benefits have a low impact; but by carefully selecting Benefits that have a strong appeal you will get more business and get it sooner.

*WA – Wrong Action

*NE – Negative Effect

The way you describe your organisation, yourself and your experience are essentially credibility factors. Clients do not buy you because of a qualification or piece of experience, they buy your solution because such things help make it credible.

Obtaining feedback

To ensure that progress is being made towards your ultimate objective, accurate feedback is necessary all the time. It is then possible to be flexible and readjust as the conversation proceeds. By observation, by waiting and listening to the client’s replies, and by asking for a comment, feedback can be assured, and monitoring questions like the following can constantly be answered:

- Am I discussing your needs?
- Is there any problem about how I am doing it?
- Is my proposition attractive, clear and convincing?
- Have I overlooked anything?

Such monitoring ensures that the client’s needs are being satisfied, keeps the client involved in the discussion, and prevents problems developing later on.

How do you keep all this organised, what are the key factors?

Presenting one’s case is simple and successful if one follows these basic rules:

- Take one point at a time
- Tell the client what it all means to them in terms of results
- Show them what it is or means – talk benefits
- Provide proof where necessary
- Check progress by obtaining constant feedback.

Obtaining feedback, maintaining a two-way aspect to the conversation (yet maintaining control) is crucial. Some of it is as simple as making sure you listen. ‘Pardon?’ Listen, really listen and use, and be seen to use, the information you are given to tailor your case. Anything else will seem like the ‘standard patter’. So the more you can link back, prefixing what you say by reference to their situation – *Because you said timing is so important, I suggest...* – the better.

Before leaving the areas of making things clear and attractive, let’s digress for a moment and consider one additional factor:

Demonstrating your product

Not every product lends itself to demonstration, but many do (if yours is not one such, by all means skip on). Where called for, an effective demonstration can strengthen the overall presentation considerably, and is another area to potentially strengthen differentiation. Seeing is believing. There is no substitute for a customer actually having the evidence of their own eyes to back up what is said by a sales person. But demonstrations must be approached in the right way; they must be effective and that means 100% effective. Anything less simply does not meet the need.

An effective demonstration starts with consideration of to whom you are demonstrating. It may be one person; it may be many. A group situation illustrates some of the problems of a formal presentation. You may feel exposed standing in front of an expectant group, and thinking beforehand about what you will say and how you will make it go smoothly and boost your self-confidence. Is the decision maker there? Or are you talking to someone who will make recommendations to someone else? This may be important to how you direct things, similarly, and perhaps more important still, are you talking to the user? If you are demonstrating, say, an office machine – a copier perhaps – who will use it? Some at the demonstration may want reassurance that they can work it easily, others may want only to check that their staff can do it, still others will think first about cost.

A successful demonstration needs preparation. Whatever you are going to demonstrate must be in good order. You must have everything you need at hand and – if possible – have checked out. If you are going to the customer’s office, where you will be. Have you sufficient space, will you be near any necessary electrical point, will everyone be able to hear you, will there likely to be interruptions? In your own office or showroom all should be set up in advance, but make sure it is.

What are the key factors? Well, many of the basic rules of selling apply: you must focus on needs, maintain interest (not all features may be of interest and a comprehensive demonstration may be neither necessary nor appreciated – ask what is important), go through to a pre-explained structure and sequence and, above all talk benefits. The job is to show the product in use; test driving a car is a good everyday example. With that in mind, remember:

- *Set up fast:* make sure you can get everything ready quickly, better still get the customer to leave you to get ready on your own. You may have to do things they would not have to, like get a machine out of its box or change an electric plug, but if it takes too long it is still likely to be read as inefficiency.
- *Make it understandable:* this is vital. Demonstrations are all too often spoilt by jargon, gobbledegook and confusion. Everything must be spelt out so that it is crystal clear. Finding it easy to understand will be read as a good sign for their own straightforward use of whatever you are demonstrating. On the other hand if you get in a muddle then people will immediately assume that, if *you* find it complicated (though dealing with it all day), then they will find it very complicated.
- *It must work!* If whatever you demonstrate does not work, does not work first time or only works with difficulty, then you have a real problem and, from the customer's point of view, quite right too. Everything must work and work perfectly.
- *Make them feel they can do it:* if you are with people who will use the machine or whatever it is, make sure they feel able to do it. Better still let them do it and prove to themselves that they can cope with it easily. This may involve not just demonstration but training, prepare how you will do it, take your time and get it right.
- *Project what you want:* and what they want. If the demonstration must stress quality, cost effectiveness or ease of use, then make sure this is a prime message that comes over.

Throughout the process the emphasis is perhaps on proof. You are not just talking about it, you can show it, they can try it – and seeing is believing. You must work to ensure everything goes exactly as you want. There are very few second chances in selling and in few parts of the process is this truer than in demonstration. Time spent to get it right is time very well spent.

Even so, with everything you put over carefully presented, there can certain problems can still occur.

iii) Dealing with resistance

Instinctively considering possible disadvantages in contemplating a decision is a natural human reaction. In selling, such considerations pose resistance, though the tendency for this to occur can be reduced. Resistance is more frequent and stronger when needs are insufficiently explored, solutions are offered too soon, or benefits and features are presented too generally or if communication is simply poor and unclear.

Some objections are not inherent in clients, but can actually be created by the person doing the selling. Resistance has both an emotional and rational content. Emotionally, the client becomes defensive or aggressive, rationally, they need a logical answer; these two elements have to be tackled separately and sequentially if resistance is to be overcome. How? First by keeping your emotions under control, by listening, pausing and thinking, acknowledging his comment – a sort of ‘sparring’ technique designed to lower the temperature.

Next, rational answers must be provided. It helps to turn the objection into a question, to establish the client’s need behind his resistance. Why are they asking this? Is it an excuse? Delaying tactics? Or perhaps they do have a point? An apparently straightforward comment such as *‘It is very expensive’* may mean a wide range of different things from *‘it is more than I expected’* to *‘No’*, from *‘It is more than I can agree’* (though someone else might) to *‘I want to negotiate’*, and so on.

Although investigating, *‘What are the snags?’* is an instinctive part of the buying process, by the time a client reaches this stage they may be sufficiently attracted by the proposal to pass on without raising objections. It pays to concentrate on resistance prevention rather than resistance cure. Agreement on stated needs, and careful selection and presentation of need-related benefits, reduces both the frequency and strength of resistance.

Some objections are simple misunderstandings, the real situation just needs explaining. Others are a challenge, especially those about price. Often such are best met head on, as the following illustrates. A seller, sitting down for a follow-up meeting with a client to discuss proposals recently submitted in writing, was immediately challenged on cost. ‘Before we get into this at all,’ he was told, ‘you must understand that we have to get the best possible price for this project.’ In a considered fashion he closed the folder in front of him and responded to the effect that ‘if it is the lowest price you want, we may as well not go on, as I know our proposals will not be the cheapest.’ The client immediately changed tack, ‘The proposals were very interesting’ He did want to discuss things. The meeting proceeded on a rather different basis. This is less technique than sheer confidence. And, selling needs that too, though it should always be based on experience and sound judgement.

You should rarely be caught out by objections you have not foreseen, at least in general terms. Thus, handling them effectively is another result of good preparation. There will always be some, however, that demand you are ‘quick on your feet’. An apparently unexpected objection, well handled, can be impressive, and taken as a display of competence.

One more point here: always bear in mind the nature of your business when dealing with objections. Take price, it is, after all, a perennial objection. There can be a defensive reaction that is almost instinctive if price is challenged, and this can lead to adjustment and negotiation. But if you say *Right, I suppose we could reduce Stage three and save some money there*, you better be ready when the prospect asks how that is possible *After all, you just said this is the best way of achieving the result*. Explanation is necessary, and a different method may lead to rather different results.

Obtaining commitment

Knowing that the objective of all selling is to obtain client commitments often obscures the need to remember how clients arrive at the point of commitment. Clients only willingly take buying decisions after they have investigated the options, weighed up the pros and cons, and are convinced that their needs will be satisfied by implementing a particular proposal. Thus, the best chance of success lies in doing a good job before the client reaches the stage of asking themselves ‘*What shall I do?*’.

Attempts to get commitment (closing) without first having made the proposal seem like to best way forward, will normally be seen by the client as pressure tactics. The bigger the decision, the greater the pressure, and the stronger the client’s resistance may be.

Closing does not cause orders, it merely converts a high level of interest into orders and low interest into refusals. Even when all is well, however, the client may not volunteer a positive commitment. Similarly, the client may want to make a commitment, but there are several variations of it, and the seller wants one particular kind. It is in these situations that closing skills are valuable; such skills concentrate the buyer’s mind on the advantages to be gained from the buying decision itself. Buying signals are important too, giving a positive sign that the sales job is complete and you should move on to close and obtain a commitment.

There are certain behaviours, questions and comments indicating a general willingness to buy that can provide such ‘buying signals’. Tone of voice, posture, hesitation, nodding, questions on details, showing acceptance in principle, or comments expressing positive interest are all examples. These can be converted into closes, being careful not to oversell when the client wants to make a commitment.

The psychology of the sales process can be important here. Although this is the crunch point, closing can sometimes be avoided because of the unpleasant possibility of getting a 'no', but the commitment must actually be asked for: the only question is exactly how it is put. So, to put it simplistically – always ask for their commitment to proceed.

Asking for a buyer's agreement, but it can be embarrassing – how exactly do you put it? There are various approaches. Here are some examples.

Direct request: For example, 'Shall we go ahead then and start getting these improvements in service levels?' This should be used in situations where the client likes to make his own decisions.

Command: For example, 'Install this new system in each regional office. It will give you the information you want much more quickly and help you to make more effective decisions.' This can be used where the client has difficulty in making a decision or has considerable respect for you.

Immediate gain: For example, 'You mentioned that this year the company really needs to improve productivity. If you can give me the go-ahead now, I can make sure that you see specific results within three months' time.' This could be used in a situation where, by acting fast, the client can get an important benefit, whereas delay might cause him severe problems.

Alternatives: For example, 'Both these approaches meet your criteria. Which one do you prefer to implement?' This could be used where you are happy to get a commitment on anyone of the possible alternatives.

'Best solution': For example, 'You want a system that can cope with occasional off-peak demands, that is easy to operate by semi-skilled staff and is presented in a form that will encourage line managers to use it. The best fit with all these requirements is our system 'X'. When's the best time to install it?' This should be used when the client has a mix of needs, some of which can be better met by the competition, but which, when taken as a whole, are best met by your solution. Essentially it links the close to a brief summary of the reasons to agree.

Question or objection: For example, 'If we can make that revision, can you get the finance director to agree to proceed?' This should be used where you know you can answer the client's objection satisfactorily.

Assumption: For example, ‘Fine. I’ve got all the information I need to meet your requirements. As soon as I get back to the office I’ll prepare the necessary paperwork and you’ll be able to start by the end of next week.’

Concession: Trade only a small concession to get agreement now or agree to proceed only on stage one.

A close should suit the client and the situation.

So far so good: the client’s answer at this point may well be ‘Yes ‘. But no matter how well a case is presented and questions handled during the sales process, the prospect will invariably have some objections to making a decision. Sometimes these objections are stated, but often they are reserved and come in the form, *‘I’ll think about it’*.

But... What do you do when, having been through everything and having prompted a seemingly positive reaction the prospect says: “Leave it with me, I’ll think about it”

When this happens, simple closes may only irritate the prospect and the way forward may be unclear. Yet it is a key stage to get over, and the best way can be to list the objections:

‘I agree you should think about it. However, it’s probably your experience also that when someone says they want to think about it it’s because they are still uncertain about some points. In order to help our thinking on these, let’s note them down.’

Then ask questions to ascertain any final points of concern. Do not write any down until each is understood, and do not answer any points raised – yet. Flush them all out and be sure there are not more to come. Then you might consider using an additional closing technique. *‘If I’m able to answer each of these points to your complete satisfaction, can we agree we’re in business?’* This is the *conditional close*. Each point listed can then be answered in turn, crossed off the list, and the prospect’s agreement with each checked, then the close is not repeated, but assumption is used to conclude matters: *‘Fine, we’re in business’*.

This will not always work, of course, but trying may tease out other information. For example, if they explain the need to “think about it” by saying that actually it must be cleared with someone else – then another route opens up. Who is this? Can you meet them? What is their perspective on the matter? If your contact is convinced, can you help them sell the proposal to their colleague?

If agreement is reached then, having made a commitment, a client may need reassurance that they have done the right thing. Therefore, always thank them, confirm that they have made a wise decision, perhaps touch once more on what will come from it, conclude and leave promptly. There may be administrative points and confirmations to be dealt with, however, beyond that, especially at a first meeting, there are dangers in prolonging the meeting. Too many of us have been chatting happily at this stage when the client suddenly says *I've been thinking* – apparently safe sales have been lost at this stage.

Good selling can often make formal closing unnecessary: 'Make people thirsty and you won't have to force them to drink' as the old saying has it.

Never avoid closing. Some of the business will go to those people most prepared to tie it down positively. It can be awkward actually to say '*Right, when do we deliver?*' (Probably because you know they could say 'no'), but not asking – or saying '*Please think about it*' leaves you open to your more positive thinking competitors.

Of course, the commitment given may not be to do business, and the necessity for 'steps on the way' has been referred to previously. The next section looks, briefly, at the important question of follow up.



The advertisement for Linköping University features a light beige background. In the top left corner is the Swedish flag logo with the text 'Sweden Sverige'. On the right side, two young women with long brown hair are smiling and leaning against a red door frame. The text 'Linköping University – innovative, highly ranked, European' is centered in a large, thin, black font. Below this, a smaller line of text reads 'Interested in Computer Science? Kick-start your career with an English-taught master's degree.' A dark blue button with a white right-pointing arrow and the text 'Click here!' is positioned below the text. At the bottom left is the 'li.u' logo followed by 'LINKÖPING UNIVERSITY' in a bold, black, sans-serif font.

4 FOLLOW UP

If every new client sprang from one, self-contained meeting, the sales process would be much easier. But, as was explained earlier, it is not like that, as you will know only too well, one contact leads to another. A meeting, another meeting, a proposal, a telephone call; they follow each other and must maintain both the initiative and the interest.

Follow up must start immediately after the first contact, and many a job has been lost by default because of poor follow up. Accurate follow up is always necessary to correct misunderstandings, carry out promised actions and to show keenness for the client's business. After each call, building goodwill is important, making the client feel it was a worthwhile contact, even if his commitment was not made, that the time spent was a valuable investment in the future. Follow-up action should be automatic and made appropriately soon after each call, while ideas are fresh. A record of what was promised should be made as a prompt to the next action. It may take a conscious effort to make sure that the logistics of the business allow the follow up action that is necessary; 'production' responsibilities have to be phased in with selling, and often demand priority.

There is not a great deal to be said about technique here, since it is much more a question of discipline and system. For example, make sure that you attempt to fix the next meeting, if appropriate, before you walk out of the current one.

What do you do if things get "stuck", you are waiting for a decision and get no answer or response to your calls.

Do not put off those, necessarily awkward, telephone calls, when the prospect needs prompting to tie down the next stage. Leave it, and the moment passes. It gets more difficult, not easier; and, in the end it may become impossible. If so good prospects can die, by default, through neglect. So, be thick skinned and persistent. Keep in touch: phone, write, e-mail and then do it again. Take responses at face value if someone says "*He's in a meeting*", assume they are and ask when it is a good time to call again. They will not make a decision to your time scale, but to theirs. Make sure you – rather than a more persistent competitor – are still there asking (and demonstrating interest) when they do.

Client development

Once you have a new client, once a project is under way that does not mean the selling stops. Selling and doing must proceed in parallel so that the client potential can be developed. Here selling, networking and doing all overlap.

Make sure that:

- Contact continues and is ongoing
- Vary the method of contact
- Make sure everyone who influences decisions is kept in touch with
- Make contacts interesting and “issue led”, that is do not just say “*Here I am*”, rather give information, update, offer advice and use this as a platform to sell (they will quickly resent endless contacts that do nothing but say “*Buy more*”)
- Watch out for and record every potential opportunity for future business.

Maintaining the flow here is vital, good client development and defining and implementing real strategy for major clients, is not only an integral part of your overall marketing, it could just be the most important part. It is always easier and lower cost to sell more to people you know (and like you) than to find more new prospects.

Mark McCormack (American sports consultant and author of “McCormack on Selling” [Century]) defines success in selling thus:

The qualities that I believe make a good seller:

- *Believe in your product*
- *Believe in yourself*
- *See a lot of people*
- *Pay attention to timing*
- *Listen to the customer – but realise that what they want is not necessarily what they are telling you*
- *Develop a sense of humour*
- *Knock on old doors*
- *Ask everyone to buy*
- *Follow up after the sale with the same aggressiveness you demonstrated before the sale*
- *Use common sense.*

I have no illusions that I’m breaking new ground with this list. These are essential, self-evident, universal qualities that all salespeople know in their heads – if not in their hearts.

This quote makes a good link to a final summary in the next section.

5 SUMMARY

There may seem a good deal to bear in mind here, and indeed there is. The logic of these approaches is sound – the most important single principle goes back to a definition used early in this chapter: selling is “helping people to buy”. Viewed this way it is not an alien process, but an inherent part of your service. A considered approach, one that deploys well-chosen approaches and which also plays to your strengths as an expert in your field, will ensure a good rate of strike. Practice makes perfect. If selling is not your stock in trade you can become skilled at it if you view it as a conscious process. Success is partly in the overall approach and partly in the detail – but believing, or hoping, you can “wing it” is simply not one of the options.

Always a fragile process, success in selling successfully is largely in the detail. What is most important? Let’s list ten factors to round things off:

1. SELLING IS PART OF MARKETING

Sales activity is part of marketing and must not take place in isolation. Thus sales people must:

- Recognise that clients see, and experience, sales in this way. For example, they may know something of an organisation ahead of a meeting (from a brochure, say); they may have checked out competitors, visited several web sites and more. They expect what happens through selling to reflect, maintain and extend any good image already projected. Any specific promises made through other media must be kept. If your web site says, *A half hour briefing will give you all you need* – then it better do just that.
- Act and talk in a way that gels well with other activities and messages.

Conversely promotion may need to reflect the fact that sales meetings are an inherent part of the process. Mismatch here just causes problems and jeopardises potential sales. Marketing must influence selling and vice versa.

2. SELLING MUST BE CUSTOMER ORIENTATED

Selling is not something that you do *to* people. It is an interactive process that must reflect the client end of the relationship. Specifically:

- Peoples' needs must be accurately identified. Only if you know what their situation (be it problem or opportunity) is, can you address it. Moreover if you address it better than competitors then what better to differentiate yourself and your organisation?
- Sales approaches must respect the individual client. Are they experienced, knowledgeable (or not), worried or confident? Sales conversations must not just specifically incorporate such information, but also *be seen* to do so. Displayed empathy scores points
- Note that for many sales situations, a sales approach must *never* appear standardised. Individuals must feel you are interested in *them*, addressing their specific situation and talking exclusively *to them*, not just saying something generalised.

A conscious focus on the client will help direct the entire communication in the right kind of way, giving it bite and giving it an edge.

3. SELLING MUST REFLECT THE BUYING PROCESS

Linked to point two, here what is advocated is not a general client orientation but a reflection of the whole process that a client is going through in making a decision. You cannot fight potential clients; you must work to help their decision making process, making it logical to choose you. Get out of kilter with a prospect and their thinking, and they will not only not see the relevance of what you are saying, they will resent it.

Buying sometimes involves not being asked a single question. How can you sell, say, a car without knowing whether the potential buyer is married, has children or a dog, what annual mileage they drive and more? Information may be volunteered, but will completely lack any credibility – it is the standard spiel. Though an example from another sector, it makes a good point. The logic dictates that clients expect to be asked questions, and for the presentation to be based on their answers. Any aspect of the client's thinking that is ignored risks failure and the likelihood that what they want will be better satisfied elsewhere.

4. SELLING DEMANDS PREPARATION

You cannot wing it. Even the best and most experienced people rarely wing it (though they may make it look like they do). Success comes from sound preparation. The first rule is simple – *always prepare*. What is actually necessary however may vary considerably: from a couple of quiet minutes before going into someone’s office, to sitting down with one or two colleagues for a couple of hours to thrash out the best way ahead. You may need to make notes, form alternative strategies, or rehearse (say for a major sale, certainly for a formal presentation). You *always* need to do something. Consider exactly what in every situation – do it – and you automatically increase your chances of success. You cannot predict exactly what will happen, you still need to be quick on your feet, but you will cope better with whatever may come your way if you are prepared.

5. SELLING MUST BE DELIVERED IN AN APPROPRIATE MANNER

Selling needs something of a soft approach, *not* lacking in persuasive power, but not weak either and certainly not unpleasantly pushy. The power – projection – that you bring to bear is important. You need confidence, authority even. Certainly people must believe you have the position, personality and profile to be credible in your role.

Empathy is the other key attribute. You need to see things from other peoples’ point of view and *be seen to do so*. Good empathy balances the powerful approach you want to bring to bear, it softens sales techniques that would otherwise be seen as “hard sell” and makes what you do acceptable as well as appropriate.

With an element of advice inherent in what you are doing, this is vital. Advice must seem soundly based. Your approach must not simply and obviously be what *you* want and what is best for you. The right blend here is worth working at. Think about how your kind of client might best want you to come over and try to match their expectations to some extent. Do not leave out the edge you want, but remember that unless what you do is acceptable it will quickly be rejected, and a conversation started with a competitor.

6. SELLING MUST INCORPORATE EFFECTIVE NEED IDENTIFICATION

Selling is not just about telling – describing – things. Success has at least as much to do with asking questions. So:

- Think about areas to question and plan how to phrase matters clearly (not least so that you can get the information you want quickly and the process does not resemble the Spanish Inquisition)
- Establish and agree that questioning is necessary (you do not want it to distract or worry people – the logic of the approach should be clear)
- Listen – as in LISTEN – too, and note if necessary, the answers

Then your presentation can be tailored around prospects' exact situation. The principle here applies whether the circumstances only permit a couple of quick questions or if you can take half an hour to really establish details (what they want, and *why* they want it). Good needs identification always puts you in a position to make a better, and better-targeted pitch and differentiate more easily from competition.

7. SELLING MUST USE MEMORABLE AND CREATIVE DESCRIPTION

There is a danger with a repetitive task that what is said becomes routine and dull. You start to abbreviate (because you have heard it all before) and the best possible case is no longer made.

There are principles to be followed here:

- Remember that unexpected clarity (especially with something expected to be complicated) delights the buyer – you need to communicate in a way that literally to ignite peoples' imagination. This is a real opportunity to shine (and to differentiate)
- Think about the best way of putting things, and do not let the way you talk about something become stale
- Keep what you say up to date, correct and fresh and make sure it is in “the clients' language” (remember too much jargon can deaden any description)
- Bring it to life. Avoid bland language – no product or service is *quite* (or even *very*) *good*, – and avoid imprecise words like – *flexible* – which attempt to be descriptive and fail (what does flexible mean, for goodness sake? This page is flexible). Work at a description to create something clear and memorable. It is one thing to say something is *sort of shiny* (wet fish?). It may be better to say it is *as smooth as silk* (conjuring up a more precise image), and better still – and more unmistakable and memorable – to say that it is *as slippery as a freshly buttered ice rink*.

Language is the most powerful tool in selling; use it to best effect.

8. SELLING MUST BE BENEFIT LED

The concept of benefits and features is key to selling and the details are not laid out here. Suffice to say that this is a crucial aspect, not least if you are to differentiate. Anyone selling a professional service must be:

- Clear what the specific benefits of their service are and able to differentiate them from features (something needing a little thought and not quite as obvious as may be first thought)
- Able to prioritise and describe benefits appropriately tailoring what they say on an individual basis – remember a benefit is a benefit, but not all benefits are relevant to every buyer
- Able to make benefits predominate in the overall conversation, relating their effect to the overall “weighing up” process that characterises making buying decisions.

Benefits should mostly lead – tell people what they get, then use features to demonstrate how this is possible. This, coupled with the powers of description already mentioned, makes for a powerful approach at the core of the sales process.

9. SELLING IS A COMPLEX PROCESS AND MUST BE MANAGED

The biggest challenge of selling is perhaps in the orchestration of the whole process. Each individual stage is essentially manageable; but there is a great deal going on. As a sales meeting progresses, you have to follow your plan and deal with anything leading you astray. You need to fine-tune what you do to accommodate unanticipated factors along the way (and thus you must notice them!). You must listen, concentrate and judge *how* you do things as well as *what* you will do. You must draw with precision from a not inconsiderable body of information about your service, clients and more, much of which must be held in your head.

Understanding what needs to be done is important here; the best sales people certainly exhibit a real awareness of the details of the process and how it works. So too is confidence, for example you may need to say *I don't know* or pause and say *Let me think about that for a moment* (though it can be awkward, this is a much better option than jumping in with an ill-considered answer).

Beyond this, what helps? Practice. Which golfer said, *It's a funny thing, but the more I practice the more good luck I seem to have?* Selling is a skill we can spend a lifetime learning. Selling is a dynamic process, and so is the environment in which it operates. Recognise that, and you are half way to dealing with it.